Well, hey there!

This is your handy reference guide to keep with you during conversation practice! Use it for ideas and inspiration and practice your small talk skills in everyday conversations! Don't let your fear and nerves hold you back... **You've got this!**

50 PHRASES FOR SMALL TALK IN ENGLISH!

Start the conversation!

Better Ways to say & answer "How are you?"

- **How's it going? / How's it going with you?**
- Not bad, thanks!
- **What have you been up to lately?**
- I've been keeping busy.
- I've been busy (training the new marketing manager).
- Nothing special, how about you?
- **How is...?**
- How is work going?
- How is your family?
- How is university?
- **How was...?**
- How was your trip to Portugal?
- How was the exam?

Making small talk at work!

HINT: Talk about how busy or quiet it has been

- I can't believe how busy/quiet we are today, can you?
- I know, we're really under the pump!
- I know, I've been flat out all week.
- Yeah, it's been dead, hasn't it?

HINT: Talk about the quality of your day / week

- **How has your day/week been?**
- It's been long / busy / hectic / (insert any adjective!)
- It has flown by.
- It's been great, thanks.

HINT: Make sure you keep the conversation going!

- **How about you?**

When you bump into someone in the staff lunch room or the elevator...

- How long have you worked here?
- What did you do before this? ← If they are new to the company.
- What are you working on at the moment? ← If not, ask about the work they are doing

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Making small talk about the weather!

HINT: Talk about current weather

- (It's a) Beautiful day, isn't it?
- Can you believe all of this rain we've been having?

HINT: Talk about future weather

- It looks like it's going to snow/rain.
- The weather's not looking great this weekend. Do you have any plans?

HINT: Talk about weather in a different location (when you are on the phone!)

- **How's the weather where you are?**
- Is it cold/hot/wet?
- I've heard it's been really cold/hot/wet/windy, lately.
- How's this weather? It's been wild/hot/freezing!

HINT: Make sure you keep the conversation going!

Making small talk about free time & hobbies

- Have you got much planned for the weekend?
- What did you get up to over the weekend?
- What do you like to do in your spare time?
- I don't know anything about _____. Where do you do that?
- Really? Tell me more about it!

HINT: Start questions with 'Have you...?'

- Have you read any good books lately?
- Have you seen any good movies recently?
- Have you tried that new restaurant down by the beach?

Making small talk about news & current affairs

HINT: Start questions with 'Did you hear/read about...?'

- **Did you hear about** (the train strike in Melbourne last week)?
- I read that Point Cook is the most multicultural suburb in Australia.
- I heard (on the radio) that the Queen is visiting next month.

Making small talk at a social/networking event

HINT: Try to find 'common ground' & look for connections. Compliments work well too!

- So, how do you know Ed?
- Have we met before? You look familiar.
- I love your dress. Can I ask where you got it from?
- It's great to (finally) put a face to the name.
- I've heard so much about you. ← This is a really common expression! A great way to respond is
- All good (things) I hope!

Ending a conversation

Perhaps you think this part is the most challenging part, but I promise you, there are just a few simple ways that native English speakers do this. We all follow the same rulebook, and once you learn the tricks, you'll be able to end any conversation with ease!

If you are at work:

- Well, I'd better get back to work.
- Well, I'd better get back to it. I'll see you round.

If you are in a social situation:

HINT: You can suggest that you have 'something else' to do

- Well, I'd better keep moving, it was nice chatting.

HINT: You can also make up an excuse to leave!

- I'm looking for _____. You haven't seen him/her around anywhere, have you?
- Have we met before? You look familiar.
- I was looking for the bathroom, do you know where it is?
- I'm going to grab a drink, I'll see you in a bit.

These are an extremely common and well-known way to leave a conversation comfortably.